

K-12 SCHOOL RATINGS

Summary

1:1 user interviews designed to get quick and clean insights about what information is needed to understand school ratings and whether that information is understandable.

Impact

Rolled out in September 2024

-  Reduced frequency of user misunderstandings by 80% on school ratings.
-  16% increase in clicks on school profiles each month.

CONTEXT & RESEARCH PLAN

Company

GreatSchools.org

Role

Lead UX Researcher

Timeline

Three weeks

Stakeholders

Product Manager,
Data Scientist,
Designer



Problem

1. Engineering planned to make school profiles more interactive in order to increase ad revenue and gather more usage data.
2. Stakeholders were confident our ratings were easy-to-use for parents.
3. But previous research suggested parents are sometimes unsure, sometimes misinterpret school ratings, like "8/10 test scores".

Research questions

1. What information about school ratings is needed to pick a school?
2. Is that information easy to comprehend?

My approach

Method

- 1:1 user interviews
 - What questions would you ask about these ratings to decide if you would consider this school?
 - For each question, shared a drafted answer and got feedback

Analysis

- Matrix analysis in Google Sheets

Recruitment

- Three rounds of n=5 participants
- Parents in the US who were sending their kid(s) to a new school in the fall

Collaboration

- Asked stakeholders about their concerns during Zoom calls
- "Soft-launching" insights in Confluence to prevent PM from being blindsided
- Shared final report in a slide deck

FINDING	RECOMMENDATION	IMPACT
One answer was disappointing - users didn't want schools to be compared across the entire state.	Out-of-scope for this project, but change the roadmap to move away from state-wide ratings to more local options.	• Small-scale and large-scale changes are in progress and in the backlog - unfortunately both are under NDA.
Some answers were understandable, but led to new questions.	Use a progressive disclosure interface to guide users away from "rabbit holes."	Rolled out in September 2024 • Reduced frequency of user misunderstandings by 80% on school ratings. • 16% month-over-month increase in clicks on the 3-5 million views of school profiles.
One new question came up.	Draft new content, conduct usability test.	
Clear understanding of what data is needed for users' jobs-to-be-done.	Decision to move forward with prototype a design, build it, and roll out the new version.	